ing brings me clarity'). Bansal Bhalja, a BAPS spokesperson, says, "Discourses help them stay away from addictions, offer strength, values and a sense of belonging with the community."

FROM PUBS TO PUJAS

Social media has turned darshan into content. Actress Sara Ali Khan's visit to Kamakhya in Guwahati pushed a Northeast shakti peeth into Instagram feeds. Global influencers Kim and Khloé Kardashian's stop at ISKCON Mumbai normalised *seva* as 'experience'. The geography is widening—from Meghalaya's Nartiang Durga, ringed by ancient monoliths, to Ladakh's monastery belts. When travel creators like Tanya Khanijow (1.1 million Instagram followers) and Deepanshu Sangwan aka 'Nomadic Indian' (1.8 million YouTube subscribers) supply enticing pictures and vlogs, audiences follow. The Triyuginarayan temple in Rudraprayag is now a sought-after 'vedic vivah' destination (see case study *'Blessed to have got married...'*).

For many, the effect endures beyond the visit. Anuj Verma, 22, from Doiwala in Dehradun district, trekked to Tungnath and Badrinath with two college friends in 2023. "It was spiritually uplifting," he says. "I am keen to try out more such circuits, especially Kedarnath." Aman Shah, 28, a musician from Tapovan near Rishikesh, rides his bike to Kedarnath yearly. "By the time I reach the shrine, my head has stopped racing." As spiritual traveller Sshivani Durga describes it, "For many young Indians, spirituality is now a personal quest—temples offer beauty, calm and a live link to heritage in a noisy world."

At the Neelkanth Mahadev Temple, perched on a forested ridge near Rishikesh and tied to the 'Samudra Manthan' legend, young trekkers ask sages less about ritual than about anxiety, sleep and fear. "It is the ache of the age," says an elderly sadhu who prefers to remain nameless. "I listen first, then give them a page to read." Not all enter the sanctum, many find peace under the pine shade.



RACHIT ROJHA, 26

YouTuber, Gurugram

'Blessed to have got married at Lord Vishnu's feet'

Rachit married fellow YouTuber Sibbu Giri in early 2025 at Triyuginarayan, a Himalayan temple dedicated to Lord Vishnu and famed as Lord Shiva and Parvati's mythic wedding site. "We got married at Vishnu Bhagwan's *charan* (feet). We are so blessed," says Rachit. Located in Uttarakhand's Rudraprayag district, Triyuginarayan is now a sought-after 'vedic vivah' destination, supported by local planners and priests. Before the eternal 'Akhand Dhuni' flame, couples exchange vows beside the Brahma Shila stone, with snow-capped ridges in view. Private ceremonies require coordination with the Tirtha Purohit Samiti and Rs 1,100 for on-site registration. ■